

BLACK SEAS CAMPAIGN RULES PACK
The Biscay & Iberian Station, 1796–1808
By James Dix



THE BISCAY & IBERIAN STATION: CAMPAIGN RULES

CAMPAIGN INTENT

This campaign represents naval operations along the Atlantic coasts of France, Spain, and Portugal during the late Revolutionary and early Napoleonic Wars. For campaign purposes, France and Spain are treated as allied powers opposing Britain, unless a scenario or campaign event states otherwise.

Players command persistent fleets, beginning with small coastal craft and escalating—through success, pressure, and political favour—towards frigate warfare and, eventually, ships of the line.

FACTIONS

This campaign is fought between the British, French and Spanish factions. Each player controls one fleet throughout the campaign. Fleets may be divided into smaller squadrons. Each fleet is led by a single named Commanding Officer. Squadrons do not have individually tracked commanders.

Each player must create and name their commanding officer. All officers begin the campaign at 'Master and Commander' (or equivalent) rank, and can only command Unrated vessels until promoted.

NAVAL RESOURCES

Each Fleet begins the campaign with 500 Naval Resources. Naval Resources represent dockyard access, manpower, stores & political priority. Additional Resources may be gained through prizes, Admiralty Favour, Merchant Convoys and scenario outcomes.

THE CAMPAIGN MAP

The Campaign Map is split into 7 Sea Zones, containing Major and Minor ports under a specific faction's control. It is not within the scope of this campaign for the ownership of these ports to be changed, but ports can be blockaded, trapping a player's ships within.

COMMANDING OFFICERS & FLAGSHIPS

The campaign centres around named Commanding Officers, assigned to a flagship. All other ships are assumed to be competently commanded but are not tracked individually. Commanding Officers are tracked using two historical ranks; Master and Commander, and Post Captain. For campaign purposes, British Master and Commander / Post Captain ranks are functionally equivalent to French Capitaine de frégate / Capitaine de vaisseau, and Spanish Capitán de fragata / Capitán de navío, respectively. All officers begin the campaign as Master and Commander.

CAMPAIGN PHASES

The Biscay & Iberian Station campaign unfolds through three shared phases, representing the gradual escalation of the war at sea and the parallel rise of individual officers from obscure commands to fleet-level responsibility. Once a phase advances, all fleets advance together, reflecting shifts in strategic priorities, political pressure, and the availability of heavier forces. Early turns are characterised by uncertainty, local initiative, and deniable violence. Later phases bring formal command, sustained operations, and decisions that carry consequences far beyond a single engagement.

PHASE I – *THE SHALLOW WAR*

This phase represents the opening years of the conflict: coastal patrols, dispatch running, privateering, and the protection or harassment of minor trade. Fighting is close to shore, intelligence is imperfect, and most actions are conducted by small, lightly commanded squadrons operating with considerable independence.

Encounters in this phase are often confused, short-ranged, and opportunistic. Success is measured less in decisive victories and more in pressure applied, prizes taken, and reputations quietly made.

Fleet Restrictions: No ships larger than a 6th rate are permitted. A maximum of one 6th rate may be included in any one squadron.

Typical Scenarios: Dispatches · Cutting Out Expedition · Commerce Raid · Reconnaissance · Shore Raid

Phase Advancement: Phase I ends when any one of the following occurs:

- A Merchant Convoy is destroyed or captured as prizes
- Any player reaches Admiralty Favour +2

PHASE II – *THE CRUISING WAR*

By now, the war has sharpened. Frigates range wider, commerce warfare intensifies, and ports become objectives rather than backdrops. Squadrons are expected to maintain a presence, disrupt enemy trade, and apply sustained pressure rather than simply seize opportunities. Commanders in this phase are no longer anonymous.

Losses attract attention, successes bring scrutiny, and actions increasingly provoke responses at a strategic level. The sea lanes are dangerous, but also lucrative.

Fleet Restrictions: 5th rates are permitted. A maximum of two frigates (5th/6th rates) may be included in any one squadron.

Typical Scenarios: Fleet Action · Blockade Run · Commerce Raid · Dispatches · Cutting Out Expedition

Phase Advancement: Phase II ends when any one of the following occurs:

- A second Merchant Convoy is destroyed
- A port is successfully blockaded for two or more consecutive turns
- A Post Captain is killed

PHASE III – *LINE OF BATTLE*

The conflict has become overt and politically charged. Fleets are committed, blockades formalised, and major actions risk diplomatic and strategic consequences. The presence of ships of the line signals that events in the theatre can no longer be ignored by admiralties or governments.

Decisions in this phase are rarely local. Every engagement is watched, every loss felt, and every victory weighed against its cost. The campaign now turns on endurance, coordination, and the ability to impose control rather than merely contest it.

Fleet Restrictions: 4th and 3rd rates are permitted. 1st and 2nd rates require special approval.

Typical Scenarios: Fleet Action · Blockade Run · Shore Bombardment · Commerce Raid · Reconnaissance

THE CAMPAIGN TURN

1 - FLEET ADMINISTRATION

- Receive Prize Money and Resources
- Return repaired ships and purchased prizes to the roster
- Purchase new ships
- Form squadrons
- Assign ships to escort Merchant Convoys
- Assign Small Ships to Inshore Scouts or Squadron Screens
- Assign Flagships and Commanding Officers

Reminder: Only ships on your roster may be assigned; ships under repair, captured, or delayed prizes are unavailable.

2. THE CAMPAIGN MAP

- Players declare squadron movements and positions
- Move Merchant Convoys & their escorts
- Resolve Interception Checks as required
- Determine which battles occur

Reminder: Interception is checked after movement and placement are completed.

3. BATTLES

- Play tabletop games, selecting an appropriate mission
- Assign damaged ships to ports for repair & pay costs immediately
- Update rosters and Ship Points
- Adjust Admiralty Favour

Reminder: Striking does not equal capture — control of the area at the end of the game determines the ship's fate.

4. ADMIRALTY PHASE (END OF TURN)

- Admiralty Favour
- Promote or replace Commanding Officers
- Exchanges or ransom prisoners
- Resolve Prizes
- Check Campaign Phase triggers
- Advance the Campaign Turn

Reminder: Admiralty Favour reflects outcomes, not effort — resolve all losses, prizes, and exchanges before advancing the turn

SECTION 1. FLEET ADMINISTRATION

Fleet Administration marks the formal opening of each Campaign Turn. It represents the work done ashore and at anchor between actions: dockyards labouring over damaged hulls, prize courts deliberating over captured vessels, Admiralty clerks reviewing reports, and captains arguing for resources, reinforcements, and recognition.

During this phase, the consequences of the previous turn are settled and preparations are made for the next. Resources are received, prizes are resolved, ships are placed on the map, and squadrons organised before operations resume at sea.

It is here—before sails are sighted and guns run out—that the true shape of the coming turn is decided.

Resources

- Campaign Turns 2 & 3: Each player gains +500 Resources.
- Campaign Turn 4 onward: Each player gains +250 Resources.

Ships

- At the start of each Campaign Turn, every ship in play is placed in one Sea Zone or one Port.
- Repaired ships and purchased prizes re-enter play at the port to which they were allocated.
- New ships may be purchased using Resources and must enter play at a designated port.
- All newly purchased or captured ships begin with Inexperienced crews.

Squadrons & Assignments

- Ships in the same Sea Zone may be freely organised into squadrons.
- Ships may move between squadrons within the same zone during this step.
- Ships in play may be assigned to escort a Merchant Convoy within the same zone.
- Small Ships may be assigned as Inshore Scouts or Squadron Screens in their current zone. These ships detach from squadrons and cannot take part in battles whilst assigned.
- Flagships are assigned at this stage. The Commanding Officer may transfer to another ship within the same Sea Zone; that ship immediately becomes the Flagship. The officer's current Crew Experience level transfers to the new Flagship. The original vessel's Crew Experience level is reduced by one step.

Commanding officers

- A **Master and Commander** may only command Unrated vessels, and cannot have Rated ships in his squadrons.
- A **Post Captain** is required to command any Rated ship, and must designate a Rated ship as a Flagship. He may then command squadrons containing Rated ships.

SECTION 2. THE CAMPAIGN MAP

The campaign map is divided into seven Sea Zones running from the Western Approaches to the Straits of Gibraltar.

Zone 1, the Western Approaches, contains Plymouth (Major) and Cork (Secondary).

Zone 2, the North Bay of Biscay, includes Brest (Major), Lorient (Secondary), and La Rochelle (Secondary).

Zone 3, the South Bay of Biscay, contains Rochefort (Major), Bayonne (Secondary), and Santander (Secondary).

Zone 4, the Galician Coast, includes Ferrol (Major), Coruña (Secondary), and Vigo (Secondary).

Zone 5, the Portuguese Coast, contains Lisbon (Major).

Zone 6, the Cádiz Approaches, contains Cádiz (Major).

Zone 7, Gibraltar & the Straits, contains Gibraltar (Major).

Together these zones represent the principal Atlantic Sea lanes and naval bases supporting operations between Britain, France, Spain, and the Mediterranean.

Campaign Map movement is resolved after Fleet Administration and determines where squadrons are operating and whether battles occur during the Campaign Turn.

Squadron Movement

All players declare their squadron movements and intended positions at the start of this phase. All players declare movements simultaneously, representing the imperfect but broadly anticipated nature of naval intelligence in this theatre.

Squadrons may remain where they are, or may move one Sea Zone North or South per Campaign Turn.

Merchant Convoys

After squadron movement has been declared, any Merchant Convoy present is moved one Zone along its route.

Merchant Convoys represent the steady flow of trade, supplies, and finance that underpins the war at sea. Although non-player forces, their movement and fate have a direct impact on Admiralty Favour and campaign escalation. At any given time, one Merchant Convoy is active on the campaign map.

Convoys follow a fixed route between Zone 1: Western Approaches, and Zone 7: Gibraltar. A convoy will start in either Zone 1 or Zone 7, and will move toward the opposite end of the route, completing its journey upon reaching the destination Zone.

Once a convoy completes its route, a new convoy is generated, starting at either Zone 1 or Zone 7. This represents the continuous movement of trade between Britain, Iberia, and the Mediterranean. At the start of each Campaign Turn, move the Merchant Convoy one Sea Zone along its route. Convoys cannot skip Zones and may not remain stationary.

Merchant Convoy Escorts

British (and Allied) forces may assign escorts to protect the convoy. Escorts move with the convoy for that Campaign Turn and are considered part of the convoy for interception purposes.

Interception:

Interception represents a squadron's ability to locate, shadow, and force contact with enemy forces operating in the same Sea Zone. It abstracts scouting, signalling, weather, pilotage, command decisions, and chance. Interception determines whether a tabletop battle occurs, not how it is fought.

After all squadron placements and Merchant Convoy movement are completed, make an Interception Check if a player squadron or a Merchant Convoy is in a Sea Zone containing enemy forces. No check is required if both sides deliberately seek battle, or if a squadron attempts to break a blockade or sortie from a blockaded port.

To resolve interception, roll 2D6. On a 7 or more, interception occurs and a tabletop battle is played. On a 6 or less, the forces miss each other. A roll of 12 always succeeds and a roll of 2 always fails, regardless of modifiers.

Apply all relevant modifiers to the roll, to a maximum of +3 or -3.

- +2 if a Merchant Convoy is present
- +1 per Inshore Scout in the Sea Zone
- +1 if the squadron includes any ships below 50% Ship Points
- -1 per Squadron Screen in the Sea Zone.

Each Small Ship may apply its modifier once per Campaign Turn and all modifiers remain subject to the ± 3 cap.

If multiple squadrons occupy the same Sea Zone, each Interception Check is resolved between two declared squadrons, and a squadron may only attempt or be the target of one interception per Campaign Turn. This prevents excessive pile-ons while still allowing coordination.

When interception succeeds, the players agree the general scenario type, based on the nature of the squadrons and the Campaign Phase, reflecting the decision of when and how to bring the enemy to action.

SECTION 3. BATTLES

IN-GAME RULES

Effects Of Rank:

- **Master and Commander:** No additional effects
- **Post Captain:** Once per game turn, may reroll one failed Skill Test for the Flagship

Musket Fire:

- Unrated ships will cause 1 damage from musket fire.
- 4th, 5th and 6th rated ships will cause 2 damage from musket fire.
- 1st, 2nd and 3rd rated ships will cause 3 damage from musket fire.

Flagships:

- **Striking the Colours:** Flagships do not make normal Strike Colours tests. A Flagship only tests for striking during a boarding action, resolved as per the core rules. At any other time, the owning player may voluntarily Strike the Colours. If the flagship becomes a Prize, the commander (if alive) is captured.
- **Boarding Actions:** If you take damage during boarding, at the end of the game roll a D3. On a 1, your commanding officer was killed during the fighting.
- **Sinking:** If a flagship is sunk, at the end of the game roll a D3. On a 1, your commanding officer is killed. On a 2, he is captured. On a 3 he is rescued and taken about a nearby friendly ship.

Capturing Ships:

- Ships that Strike the Colours during a Boarding Action are captured. A struck ship that is not on fire may be captured by moving up alongside, as per a Boarding Action. However, no Skill Test is required to grapple or board a ship that has Struck its Colours.
- Once captured:
 - The ship becomes a Prize
 - It remains in play
 - It may not fire, board, or initiate actions
 - It activates under the capturing players control next turn
- The capturing ship is considered to have detached crew and may not initiate any further boarding actions this game.

Prize Ships:

- A Prize ship must move toward a table edge designated by the capturing player, and may be attacked, boarded, or recaptured. A Prize ship must move each activation if able and may not voluntarily change course.
- A Prize ship may be recaptured by boarding it (as normal), or destroyed by gunnery or fire. If recaptured, control immediately changes hands. There is no limit to how many times a ship may change hands during a battle, but if recaptured by the original owner it does not count as a Prize for them.

POST-BATTLE RESOLUTION

Struck Ships:

At the end of the game, resolve each struck ship:

- If a struck ship is within 3" of at least one enemy ship and no friendly ships, then it becomes a Prize.
- If a struck ship is within 3" of at least one friendly ship and no enemy ships then it is recovered.
- If a struck ship is not within 3" of any ships, possession will generally fall to whichever player is in control of the battlefield. Control is normally determined by which player has the majority of active ships remaining in the area, however, players should agree logical conclusions between themselves – i.e. that there are enough ships able to actually take control, and so on.

Experience:

Check if any ships crews are eligible for an experience level upgrade:

- **Ships Crews:** Crews are either Inexperienced, Regular or Veteran. A ship's crew advances one level if any one of the following occurs:
 - The ship participates in and survives two games without striking its colours
 - The ship participates in two successful missions
 - The ship directly captures or destroys an enemy ship of equal or greater rate

National Limitations: British crews advance normally. French and Spanish crews may only advance from Regular to Veteran when visiting a Major Port.

Commanding Officers:

Check if any officers have been captured, or killed:

- **Captured Commanding Officers:** become Prisoners of War and may be exchanged or ransomed.
- **Killed Commanding Officers:** If a Commanding Officer is killed, a Lieutenant assumes temporary command. The flagship suffers -1 to all Skill Tests until it visits port to receive a replacement Commanding Officer.

Admiralty Favour: Note any events that will affect Admiralty Favour; changes are applied during the Admiralty Phase.

Prizes: Secured prizes must be sent to a designated friendly port and are rolled for at the end of the Campaign Turn.

Repairs: Designate where and how any damaged ships will be repaired, and deduct the cost from your Resources.

Update Roster: Apply all relevant changes to your fleet roster. Note that ship values may change as a result of Crew Experience, for example, which affects Prize Money.

SHIP POINTS & CRITICAL HITS

After each game, ships retain their damage - Ship Points are not reset between games. Repairs may be carried out between games using Naval Resources. This represents cumulative hull damage, rigging wear, crew exhaustion, and structural fatigue.

Critical Hits received from shooting persist for the duration of the game and into the campaign, but some can be mitigated each game turn with a skill test. Specific conditions such as Quarterdeck Hit as a result of a Collision, or Sail Hit as a result of tacking, only last one turn as per the rules, representing limited, temporary chaos.

Quarter Deck Hit:

Persistent Effect:

- No change of direction or Level of Sail without a Skill Test
- Shooting suffers -1 to hit

Mitigation:

- Pass a Skill Test at start of activation to ignore effects this activation only

Additionally, roll a D6. On a 1, your commanding officer is killed, gain the Crew Hit critical damage.

Gun Deck Hit:

Persistent Effect:

- Affected gun position fires 2 fewer cannons (minimum 0)

Mitigation:

- None

Rudder / Steering Hit

Persistent Effect: At the start of each activation, roll D3:

- 1: Turn full arc left after move
- 2: No change of direction
- 3: Turn full arc right after move

Mitigation:

- Pass a Skill Test to ignore the effect this activation only

Campaign Damage: Structural Damage

Crew Hit

Persistent Effect:

- Ship suffers -1 to all Skill Tests for the rest of the game

Campaign Damage: If the ship suffers two or more Crew Hits in the same game, reduce crew experience level by one level after the battle, down to a minimum of until Inexperienced. Recovery requires a visit to a Major Port.

Sails Hit:

Persistent Effect:

- Reduce Rate of Knots by -2
- May not increase Level of Sail above its current level

Mitigation:

- Pass a Skill Test to ignore the effect this activation only

Mast Hit:

Persistent Effect:

- As per core rules.

Campaign Damage: Structural Damage

PORTS & REPAIRS

Ports are rated by their capacity to support naval operations. Any Squadron can send one or more ships for repair to a friendly port in their current Sea Zone, or an adjacent Sea Zone.

Port Types and Repair Limits:

Major Port: Major Ports represent full dockyard facilities, trained labour, stores, and administrative authority.

- Ship Point repairs cost 1 Resource per point
- Repairing less than 25% of total Ship Points: ship misses 0 Campaign Turns
- Repairing 25% - 50% of total Ship Points: ship misses 1 Campaign Turns
- Repairing 50% or more of total Ship Points: ship misses 2 Campaign Turns
- May repair Structural Damage
 - Structural Damage costs 10 Resources per instance
- May restore losses caused by Crew Hits by one experience level, up to Veteran
- Post Captain promotions and replacements may be confirmed

Secondary Port: Secondary Ports represent limited dockyard capacity and regional administration.

- Ship Point repairs cost 2 Resources per point
- Repairing less than 50% of total Ship Points: ship misses 1 Campaign Turn
- Repairing 50% or more of total Ship Points: ship misses 2 Campaign Turns
- May restore losses caused by Crew Hits by one experience level, up to Regular
- Post Captain promotions may be confirmed

Roadstead/Anchorage (At-sea repairs): Roadstead repairs represent emergency work carried out using ship's crew and carried stores.

- Jury-rig repairs only
- May restore up to **D3 of lost Ship Points** at **no Resource cost**
- Repairs are completed immediately
- **Cannot** repair:
 - Structural Damage
 - Crew Hit losses
- Cannot confirm promotions or replacements

SECTION 4. ADMIRALTY PHASE

ADMIRALTY FAVOUR

Each fleet tracks **Admiralty Favour** on a five-step scale: **-2 | -1 | 0 | +1 | +2**

All fleets begin the campaign at **0**.

Admiralty Favour represents political confidence, public reputation, and the degree of trust placed in a commander by their Admiralty. Success at sea earns attention; failure attracts scrutiny. A brilliant action may open doors to heavier ships and greater autonomy, while a costly mistake can see resources restricted and careers cut short.

Gaining and Losing Favour: Admiralty confidence is hard won and easily lost; success must be proven, but failure speaks for itself.

A fleet gains **+1 Favour** for actions that demonstrate effectiveness or bring visible advantage. This includes successfully escorting a Merchant Convoy to its destination, capturing an enemy rated ship or merchant vessel, maintaining a declared blockade for two consecutive turns, completing a specific Admiralty mission, clearly defeating a superior force, or capturing an enemy officer. Such events represent tangible strategic gain or public prestige.

A fleet loses **-1 Favour** for setbacks that suggest weakness, misjudgement, or loss of control. This includes losing a 5th or 4th Rate ship, allowing a Merchant ship to be captured, abandoning an Admiralty objective, ending a game with multiple ships struck, lost, or sunk, or through the loss of a rated flagship.

More serious reverses cause a loss of **-2 Favour**. This applies to the loss of a 3rd Rate or higher, the destruction of a Veteran-crewed rated ship, or a public disaster such as a failed blockade or the annihilation of a convoy, as agreed by the players. These events carry political weight beyond the immediate tactical result.

If the Commanding Officer is killed, reduce Admiralty Favour by 1 step immediately. This is in addition to any Favour loss already triggered by the circumstances of the battle.

Effects of Admiralty Favour: Admiralty Favour reflects the confidence placed in your command, directly influencing the ships, resources, and political support available to your fleet.

At **+1 (In Good Standing)**, the fleet enjoys political support and improved access to resources. The commander may recruit 3rd and 4th Rates, and once per Campaign Turn one ship may be repaired at half the usual Resource cost.

At **+2 (High Favour)**, these benefits remain in effect and confidence in the command is at its height. The fleet may recruit 1st and 2nd Rates, once per Campaign Turn one ship may complete repairs one turn faster than usual, and once per game the player may reroll a single failed Skill Test.

At **0 (Under Scrutiny)**, the fleet remains viable but unremarkable. Commanders may be promoted as normal, but no additional benefits are granted.

At **-1 (Disfavour)**, confidence begins to wane. The fleet may not purchase ships larger than those it already possesses, and replacement crews are limited to Regular.

At **-2 (Loss of Confidence)**, trust has eroded. No new ships above 6th Rate may be acquired, replacement crews are limited to Inexperienced, and if the fleet remains at -2 for two consecutive Campaign Turns, roll 1D6 at the end of the second turn. On a result of 1-2, the commanding officer is recalled and replaced, representing political intervention and the loss of confidence in theatre command.

PROMOTE OR REPLACE COMMANDING OFFICERS

If a Commanding Officer has been killed in action or dismissed by the Admiralty, they will be replaced with an officer of equal rank, with Admiralty Favour reset to 0.

When a new Commanding Officer is assigned, the new officer will not gain the effects of their rank until after their first game – Seniority and/or popularity does not carry over. This reflects the reality that replacements are often competent, but untested. The player will, of course, need to create and name their new officer.

A Master and Commander may be promoted to Post Captain once the following conditions are met.

- The officer has personally survived at least two battles without striking their colours
- The player's Admiralty Favour is currently 0 or higher
- The Flagship is currently in the same Sea Zone as a friendly Major or Secondary Port

EXCHANGE OR RANSOM PRISONERS

Captured Commanding Officers may be exchanged during the campaign. Alternatively, they may be ransomed (100 Resources for Master and Commander, 200 Resources for Post Captain). Captured Commanding Officers who are exchanged or ransomed are unavailable for the next Campaign Turn and do not automatically return to their previous ship or command – you may need to replace your new officer with the old!

RESOLVE PRIZES

Even after striking, a captured ship remained a fragile prize. Storms, recapture, sabotage, and sheer misfortune claimed many vessels before they could be safely brought into port and condemned by a prize court.

For each ship captured as a prize and sent to a designated friendly port, roll 1D6:

- **1 — Lost on Passage**
The prize is wrecked, recaptured, scuttled, or otherwise fails to reach port. No benefit is gained.
- **2–3 — Prize Money**
Sell the ship for its value in Resources.
Merchant ships are always resolved using this result.
- **4–5 — Purchased by Admiralty**
Add the ship to your roster with an Inexperienced crew.
- **6 — Decision Delayed**
The prize remains unresolved. Roll again during the next Campaign Turn.
On this re-roll, treat a result of 1 as 2–3 (Prize Money) instead.

CHECK CAMPAIGN PHASE TRIGGERS

Determine whether any conditions have been met to advance the campaign to the next Phase and apply any new restrictions or permissions immediately.

ADVANCE THE CAMPAIGN TURN

Increase the Campaign Turn by one and begin the next turn with Fleet Administration.